

of the production of imitations of ancient porcelain than Daoguang Reign. Take the porcelains with colourful patterns for instance, in Daoguang Reign, imitations of Yongzheng porcelains, in the *Fencai*, the contrasting colours, the ink colours, the rouge red gilt on white ground, and those of Qianlong *Qinghua* porcelains were very popular. Besides, there were a lot of porcelain imitations of bamboo ware and lacquerware, whose high artistic attainments could be found in the imitation of bamboo brush pot in yellow glaze in collection of the Palace Museum and the imitation of bamboo hat stand (*maotong*) in collection of Jiangxi Provincial Museum.

In the Xianfeng Reign, imitation of Ming's Chenghua porcelains in contrasting colours and Qing's Qianlong porcelain with soft coloured decoration became the trend of the time. The imitations produced in civil kilns of Kangxi porcelains with five-colours, though roughly made, become very valuable now because only few of them were passed on to the later generations.

In Tongzhi Reign, porcelain industry in Jingdezhen began its recovery from decline. Most of the imperial kiln's products were imitations of ancient porcelain. For example, in the 13th year of Tongzhi Reign, the majority of imperial kiln's products were imitations. According to product records, three types of the quadrangular pots were all imitations of the Jun and Ge kilns' porcelains. A lot of vases, *Zun*, bowls and plates were also imitations of ancient porcelain.

In Guangxu Reign, the imitations of ancient porcelain, in either colour glazes, *Fencai* or *Qinghua*, surpassed their counterparts in the previous reigns so long as the porcelain and glaze quality was concerned. They looked no different from the original masterpieces, yet brought forth some new artistic characteristics under the influence of the painting styles then, winning the favours of both domestic and foreign merchants despite of their high prices. The *Fencai* eggshell bowl decorated with flower and bird pattern, an imitation of Yongzheng porcelain, now in collection of the Nanjing Museum, looks exactly the same as the original one in terms of modelling, glaze and decoration.

Besides, the production of imitations in Guangxu Reign was featured by large quantities and rich varieties. In the early Guangxu Reign, the majority of imitations were those of the Song Dynasty's porcelain and colour-glazed porcelain. In the middle stage, imitations of Ming porcelain with unrestrained styles caught the limelight. In the later stage, most of the imitations were those of the early Qing palace porcelains.

New headway was made in imitation production in Xuantong Reign. As *The Assessment of Porcelains Made in Ming and Qing Dynasties* (《明清瓷器鉴定》), written by Geng Baochang, puts it, "the *Qinghua* incense burner with landscape and figure pattern and with a stamp of Hall of Breeding (繼世堂) made in the second year of Xuantong Reign, now in collection of Guangdong Provincial Museum, is very similar to the original one in Kangxi Reign in terms of modelling, glaze, decoration and *Qinghua* tone and is of high craftsmanship." So great achievements were made in the production of porcelain imitations in Xuantong Reign, which reflected high technological skills so long as the use of colour-glazes and decorative drawings was concerned. This further facilitated the development of porcelain industry and commodity economy in Jingdezhen.

In the Qing Dynasty, porcelains made especially for palace use came from civilian, imperial, official and ministers' kilns, resulting in the popularity of various kinds of seals (stamps) on the porcelains. In the late Qing Dynasty, such seals witnessed further development.

Seals, as a kind of decoration on the porcelains matching up with patterns, can add beauty to the porcelains. They can be divided into various kinds according to their contents, such as marks of time or reign title, decorations, craftsmen's names, hall names, and auspicious words.

There were two kinds of seals of time: one, used on the porcelains made in Imperial Factory, marks the emperors' reigns, such as the six-Chinese-character seal meaning "Made in Daoguang Reign of the Great Qing Dynasty (大清道光年制)" and the four-Chinese-character seal meaning "Made in Daoguang Reign (道光年制)"; the other, used on porcelains made in civil kilns, adopts the heavenly stems and earthly branches, such as those indicating "Made in a *Kuiyou* year in Jiaqing Reign (嘉慶癸酉年制)" or "Made in a *Dingyou* year in Daoguang Reign (道光丁酉年制)". The specific year was patterned by the heavenly stems and earthly branches.

Seals of decorations included: those of religious symbols (such as the Eight Diagrams, the Taiji Pattern, the Eight Auspicious Objects, the Seven Treasures and the matter held by the Eight Immortals), those of curios-and-antiques (such as the Eight Treasures and lute, chess, calligraphy and painting) and those of auspicious drawings (such as bats and peaches, whose Chinese pronunciation were respectively similar to those of "happiness" and "longevity").